

Phase-1 models

Wednesday, 20 May 2026 10:03 AM

FREE MODELS (Development + Early MVP)

Use:

- Gemini Flash Free → stories, activities, reflections, multilingual support, JSON APIs
- Qwen2-VL Free → image upload understanding + child creation reflection
- DeepSeek Chat Free → structured metadata extraction and fallback JSON generation

This Covers:

- Story generation
- Activity generation
- Parent guidance
- Character suggestions
- Child reflections
- Hindi stories
- Image analysis
- Structured API responses

Enough to build entire Phase-1 + Phase-1.1 almost free.

PAID MODEL STRATEGY (Later)

Best Single Paid Model:

GPT-4o

Use it for:

- stories
- activities
- image understanding
- reflections
- multilingual
- structured outputs

One model can handle almost your entire platform.

Best Long-Term Architecture

Initial Stage

OpenRouter

→ Gemini Flash Free

→ Entire backend

Later Upgrade

OpenRouter

→ GPT-4o

→ Premium experience

This gives you:

- one integration
- easy model switching
- low maintenance
- scalable architecture for future growth.

App Feature / Use Case	Why You Need This Model	Best Free/Open Model (Phase-1/1.1)	Best Single Paid Model Later	Why Good For Your Platform	Dedicated Better Model Later (Optional)
Story Generation	Generate child-safe stories	Gemini Flash Free / Qwen2.5	OpenAI GPT-4.1	Strong creativity + structured outputs + multilingual	Claude Sonnet
Activity Generation	Create hands-on STEM activities	Gemini Flash	GPT-4.1	Excellent reasoning for step-by-step activities	Claude Sonnet
Story Reflection	Encourage child emotionally	Gemini Flash	GPT-4.1	Emotional tone control good	Claude
Activity Reflection	Analyze what child built	Gemini Flash	GPT-4.1	Good descriptive capability	Claude
Image Reflection	Describe uploaded image positively	Qwen VL / Gemini Vision	GPT-4o	Strong multimodal reasoning	Gemini Pro Vision
Character Suggestion	Suggest characters for stories	Gemini Flash	GPT-4.1	Good contextual creativity	Claude
Parent Guidance	Explain learning benefits to parents	Gemini Flash	GPT-4.1	Good educational summaries	Claude
Metadata Extraction	Extract skills, category, difficulty	DeepSeek Chat	GPT-4.1 Mini	Cheap + structured JSON generation	DeepSeek Reasoner
Prompt Rewriter	Improve prompts internally	DeepSeek Chat	GPT-4.1	Strong prompt optimization	Claude
Safety Validation	Check unsafe content	Gemini Flash	GPT-4.1 Mini	Reliable moderation-like filtering	OpenAI Moderation
Multilingual Translation	Hindi/Regional language stories	Gemini Flash	GPT-4.1	Strong multilingual support	Gemini Pro
JSON Structured Output	Stable frontend-compatible responses	Gemini Flash	GPT-4.1	Excellent JSON adherence	Claude
Future Voice Storytelling	TTS + narration later	Edge-TTS / Piper	OpenAI Realtime	Natural child-friendly voice	ElevenLabs
Future Embeddings	RAG + semantic retrieval	BGE-small / Nomic	OpenAI Embeddings	Stable embedding quality	Jina AI

YOUR BEST STRATEGY (Highly Recommended)

Instead of integrating:

- separate story model
- separate image model
- separate reflection model

initially...

Use:

ONE MODEL FOR EVERYTHING

This is the smartest solo-founder approach.

BEST SINGLE MODEL STRATEGY

Phase-1 + Phase-1.1

Use:

[OpenRouter](#)

with:

Gemini Flash

WHY GEMINI FLASH?

Because it supports:

- stories
- activities
- structured JSON
- multilingual
- image understanding
- reflections
- fast responses
- low cost
- generous free tier

This lets you:

build entire platform with ONE integration

YOUR INITIAL AI STACK

Layer	Recommendation
AI Gateway	OpenRouter
Primary Model	Gemini Flash
Vision Tasks	Gemini Vision
Fallback Model	DeepSeek Chat
Embeddings Later	BGE-small
Voice Later	Edge-TTS

VERY IMPORTANT

Do NOT optimize models too early.

Your biggest risks are NOT:

- model quality
- latency
- token cost

Your biggest risks are:

- weak product flow
- low retention
- poor activity quality
- weak emotional engagement

IDEAL EVOLUTION

Stage-1 (NOW)

ONE MODEL:

Gemini Flash

Handles:

- stories
- activities
- reflections
- image analysis
- multilingual

Stage-2 (When Users Grow)

Add:

cheap model

+

premium fallback

- Example:
- DeepSeek → draft
 - GPT-4.1 → refine

Stage-3 (Large Scale)

- Dedicated models:
- vision model
 - reasoning model
 - recommendation model
 - speech model
- ONLY if needed.

🚀 MY RECOMMENDATION FOR YOU

DO THIS:

OpenRouter
→ Gemini Flash
→ Entire Phase-1 + 1.1
This is:

- cheapest
- simplest
- fastest
- most maintainable
- best for solo founder

And later:
you can switch models WITHOUT changing backend architecture.
but give me a free model for my dev env for all the usecases

Use Case	Recommended FREE Model For Dev	Why Good For Your Use Case	Runs Where	Vision Support	Structured JSON	Notes
Story Generation	Gemini Flash Free	Very creative + fast + multilingual	OpenRouter	✗	✓	Best overall free choice
Activity Generation	Gemini Flash Free	Good reasoning + step generation	OpenRouter	✗	✓	Excellent for STEM activities
Reflection Generation	Gemini Flash Free	Child-friendly tone generation	OpenRouter	✗	✓	Very stable outputs
Character Suggestions	Gemini Flash Free	Strong contextual creativity	OpenRouter	✗	✓	Great for mythology/science themes
Parent Guidance	Gemini Flash Free	Good educational explanations	OpenRouter	✗	✓	Good clarity
Metadata Extraction	DeepSeek Chat Free	Strong structured extraction	OpenRouter	✗	✓	Cheap and accurate
JSON Output APIs	DeepSeek Chat Free	Strong JSON formatting	OpenRouter	✗	✓	Good backend stability
Upload Image Reflection	Qwen2-VL Free	Good image understanding	OpenRouter	✓	Partial	Good enough initially
Child Upload Description	Qwen2-VL Free	Vision + reasoning	OpenRouter	✓	Partial	Best free vision option
Safety Validation	Gemini Flash Free	Better safer outputs	OpenRouter	✗	✓	Add your own validation too
Hindi Story Generation	Gemini Flash Free	Excellent multilingual support	OpenRouter	✗	✓	Very useful for India
Future Voice Narration	Edge-TTS	Completely free TTS	Local	✗	✗	Lightweight
Embeddings (Later)	BGE-small-en-v1.5	Excellent free embeddings	Local/HF	✗	✗	Use later only
OCR/PDF Reading	PaddleOCR + Gemini Flash	Cheap and simple	Local + OpenRouter	Partial	✗	Good enough initially

🚀 BEST SIMPLE DEV STACK FOR YOU

ONLY 3 MODELS NEEDED INITIALLY

Purpose	Model
All text generation	Gemini Flash Free
Image understanding	Qwen2-VL Free
Structured extraction fallback	DeepSeek Chat Free

- That's enough for:
- stories
 - activities
 - reflections
 - image uploads
 - metadata
 - multilingual support

🎯 EVEN SIMPLER OPTION (BEST FOR YOU)

You can ACTUALLY use:

ONLY GEMINI FLASH FREE

for almost EVERYTHING initially.

- Including:
- stories
 - activities
 - reflections
 - JSON output
 - Hindi support

And later use:

- Qwen2-VL only for image uploads



BEST SOLO-FOUNDER STRATEGY

DEV ENV (NOW)

Layer	Recommendation
API Gateway	OpenRouter
Main Model	Gemini Flash Free
Vision Model	Qwen2-VL Free
Backend	FastAPI
DB	PostgreSQL
Storage	Local initially
Analytics	PostHog Free
Monitoring	Sentry Free



IMPORTANT REALITY

DO NOT spend money on:

- GPT-4
- Claude
- premium APIs

until you validate:

- user retention
- story quality
- engagement
- parent interest

You can build:

entire Phase-1 + Phase-1.1

almost FREE.



LATER SINGLE PAID MODEL OPTION

If later you want:

ONLY ONE PAID MODEL

Use:

GPT-4o

Because it handles:

- stories
- vision
- reasoning
- multilingual
- structured outputs

with ONE integration.

But for NOW:

Gemini Flash Free is more than enough.